

Ostinati, loops, and riffs

A piece of musical material repeated over and over may be called a riff, an ostinato, or a loop. While they are essentially the same thing, the different terms are used within different genres of music.

SEE ALSO

◀ 38–39 Triplets and tuplets

◀ 162–163 Counterpoint

Rock bands 190–191 >

Blues and jazz 198–199 >

Ostinato

Italian for obstinate, ostinati are brief phrases that are repeated over and over in a piece of classical music. Ostinati may be varied or transposed, but their similarity is their hallmark. “Open” rhythmic ostinati are less restrictive, whereas melodic (“closed”) ostinati are more limited as melodies are restricted by their harmonic implications.

The sixteenth-note triplet is featured in this distinctive ostinato.

The ostinato is two measures in length.

- 139 ▽ **Rhythmic ostinati**
One of the most famous rhythmic ostinati ever written is this snare drum rhythm, which underpins the melody in Maurice Ravel's *Bolero* (1928).

▽ Melodic ostinati

In Frédéric Chopin's *Berceuse*, D-flat major, Op. 57 (1843), one of the most well-known melodic ostinati appears in the left hand.

Andante

p

dolce

Ground bass

A type of ostinato, ground bass consists of a repeated harmonic motif in the bass part of the music. One of the most famous ground bass lines is the lowest part of *Canon in D*, written by Johann Pachelbel in the 17th century. This eight-note ground bass pattern occurs 28 consecutive times in the piece.

- 140 △ **Canon in D, Johann Pachelbel**
These eight simple notes imply the following rich harmonic progression: D major, A major, B minor, F# minor, G major, D major, G major, A major.